

bored, and the best passages of the new book are when he visits places that have changed beyond recognition such as Singapore; or those he didn't visit in the old one. Iran, perhaps rather wisely, refused Theroux a visa, and he is forced to travel through central Asia. His cruelly funny portrait of everyday life under the last days of the unlamented former dictator of Turkmenistan, Saparmyrat Niyazov, stands out as the best bit of travel writing in the entire book.

He devotes about a fifth of the book to India, which he doesn't really pretend to like. That he also isn't very interested is clear from the start. He flies from Tashkent to Amritsar on a flight on which all the passengers—male and female—are Sikhs, and then tells us that every one of the Sikh women was wearing a sari. A sari? He then reads *zindabad* written on an Amritsar wall, and tells us confidently that the word means “a strike”. He is not impressed by the few changes he sees. In Amritsar, “Joginder’s greasy café and pastry shop was now Joginder’s greasy Internet café and pastry shop and looked 200 years old.” And then out come the pastiches of Indian English (“Mungo jews”, which means mango juice) and the generalisations. He refers to the “craving” of Indians to have the world’s good opinion of them, and “their moralising and disquisitionary nature, their unembarrassed pleasure of speechifying, their love of the rotund and the sententious, and the enduring quaintness of their customs”. He does not like the dirt, or the “crowds of the cringing and the limbless”, and describes life in India as “a monotony of frotteurism...an unending experience of nonconsensual rubbing”.

Theroux is conscious of how age has made him more curmudgeonly as well as less visible and maybe less interesting to his fellow train passengers. Perhaps, this helps explain why so many of his conversations are rather dull than those in *The Great Railway Bazaar*, and why he sees little hope for the future. He returns even gloomier and more rotund than when he left—telling his deflated readers that “travel is the saddest of pleasures.” His pessimism has become all-pervasive: “The world is deteriorating and shrinking to a ball of bungled desolation”. He must have been pleased to see Penelope. ■

Magnificent Obsession

It makes you wonder, why another book on the wonder?



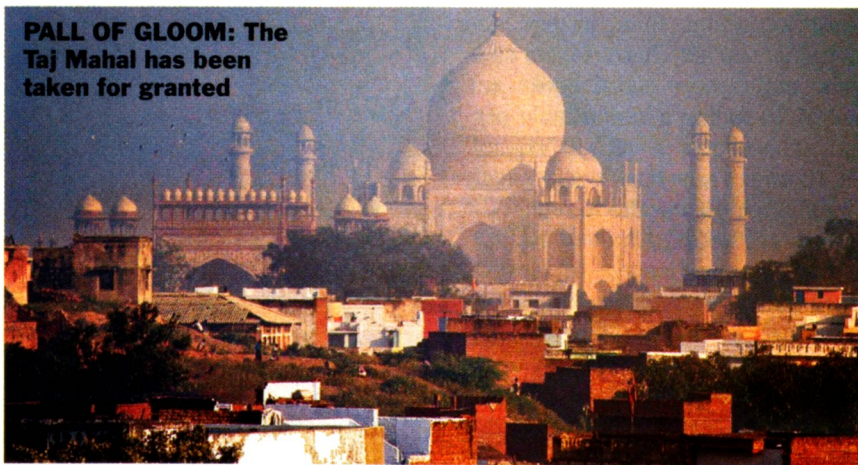
TAJ MAHAL
by GILES TILLOTSON
Penguin
Price: Rs 399
Pages: 177

■ By Dilip Bobb

Here’s a monumental idea. Take a percentage of royalty on all the books written on the Taj Mahal and use the money to give the area surrounding the world’s most extravagant monument of eternal love a much-needed makeover. Not perhaps in the reign of the current chief minister of Uttar Pradesh. She, remember, had her own plan to marry commerce with art and heritage. That, sadly, is the tragedy with such wondrous

built for his lost wife. The list of writers who have produced the most authoritative books on the Taj Mahal are dominated by foreigners: Diana and Michael Preston, Ebba Koch, Wayne E. Begley and Elizabeth Moynihan, to name a few. We now have another, Giles Tillotson, a Brit, who has fallen under the spell of India and its historical monuments. He taught History of Art at the University of London before moving to India, where he now lives and writes. He has an enviable knowledge of India’s cultural and artistic heritage (his previous book was on Jaipur) but is handicapped by, well, history.

So much has been written on the Taj that it seems pretty much a dry well in literary terms. To be fair, Tillotson



PALL OF GLOOM: The Taj Mahal has been taken for granted

monuments like the Taj. We Indians tend to take such priceless legacies too much for granted. The graffiti and ugly defacement of some of India’s most treasured historical monuments bear adequate testimony to that. Millions of foreigners will visit India just to get a chance to see one of the Seven Wonders of the World—and no one can deny that it is deserving of that distinction. Yet, most Indians would rather hit the Ridge in Shimla or the Mall in Mussoorie or Ooty than brave the heat and dust and chaos of Agra.

That is much the same story, literally, when it comes to books on the sublime creation a grieving emperor

was asked to write the book as part of the Wonders of the World series and he has tried to add new elements wherever he can. The story of the Taj Mahal is essentially a love story, unique and royal, which does give it an enduring cachet. Tillotson tries to inject some contemporary twists to an ancient story, a Bollywood connection for instance (*Bunty aur Babli*), Mayawati’s crass corridor plan and recent controversies related to its origins and dubious claimants to the monument itself. The rest, predictably, is well-trodden ground, much like the precincts of one of the most magnificent structures ever built. ■